

THE MAIN EVENT

Tibet Turnaround

For prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, it was more than a trip down memory lane. It was yet another waystation in his Peace Yatra. As soon as the Indian delegation settled at Hotel Regis in Beijing, a six-member team led by Wang Yi, Chinese vice-foreign minister, landed up with its own draft.

REUTERS



VAJPAYEE WITH CHINESE PRESIDENT HU JINTAO IN BEIJING

The Indian side was led by Brajesh Mishra. Till well past midnight they battled over three words. The Chinese insisted India should recognise Tibet as an inalienable part of the country. India said it would be consistent with its stand that only the Tibet Autonomous Region (TAR) was part of the People's Republic of China. When the document was finally signed, India had remained steadfast on TAR, a major victory for Vajpayee. *India Today*, July 7, 2003

ALSO

- Astronaut Kalpana Chawla dies in the Columbia disaster
- India refuses to send troops to Iraq in support of the US-led coalition forces
- First low-cost, no-frills airline Air Deccan starts operations

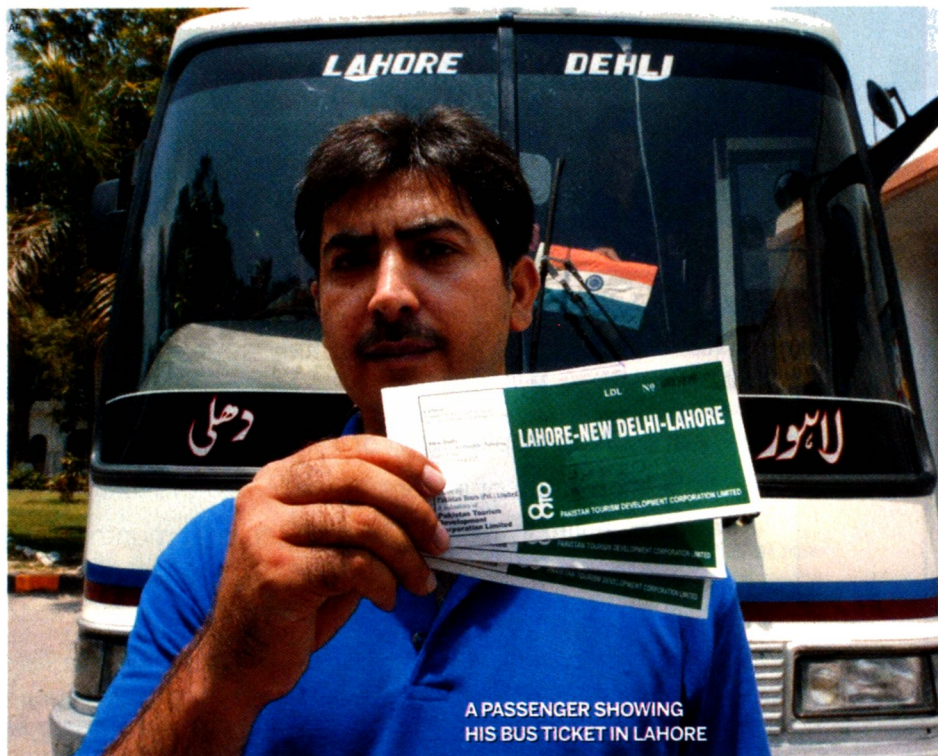
|2003| LAHORE BUS

Road to Reconciliation

The service has survived near-wars and furious cross-border rhetoric

It was raining in Delhi at five minutes past 6 a.m. on July 13 when Seth Singh drove the Lahore-bound bus out of the Capital's Dr Ambedkar Stadium bus terminal. Flagging off the bus under a forest of umbrellas was Major General (retd) B.C. Khanduri. The rain was an auspicious start for the first bus service in 18 months after diplomatic ties with Pakistan were snapped following the December 13, 2001, attack on India's Parliament. The choice of a former general was incidental. Khanduri was then transport minister in the A.B. Vajpayee Cabinet. The air-conditioned bus carried 13 passengers travelling to meet families in Pakistan and 19 mediapersons for the 12-hour ride into the capital of Pakistan's Punjab province 530 km away. Screened by bomb and dog squads of the Border Security Force, the bus received a tumultuous welcome when it crossed over into Pakistan at the Wagah border at around 6 p.m.. Launched on February 19, 1999, when prime minister Vajpayee crossed the border in the first bus as a symbolic gesture of peace, the service is called the Sada-e-Sarhad (call of the frontier). The bus service was one of the three facets—others being train and air links—of the revival of India-Pakistan links. "We flagged off the bus with hope and expectations of a lasting peace with Pakistan. Sadly we have always been disappointed," says Khanduri. The service has, however, endured the whimsical nature of ties between both countries. Operated by the Pakistan Tourism Development Corporation and the Delhi Transport Corporation on Mondays, Wednesdays and Fridays, it has survived near-wars, terror strikes and furious cross-border rhetoric after the 26/11 attacks last year. A third weekly service was added last year. It is perhaps a reminder of how people-to-people ties must endure for a lasting peace.

by Sandeep Unnithan



A PASSENGER SHOWING HIS BUS TICKET IN LAHORE

PASSENGERS PAY RS 1,500 FOR A TRIP ON THE DOSTI BUS OR THE SADA-E-SARHAD SERVICE.